

DR. OLINDA JOHNSON, PhD, RNC, CNS, APN

Speaker Compensation, Expense, & Booking Framework

An internal reference for setting fair-market rates, standardizing what hosts cover, and capturing every legitimate business deduction at year end.

How this framework works

Three documents do the work of professional speaker representation. You don't need an agent or a bureau — you need to send the right paperwork in the right order:

- 1. One-Sheet** — sent first, with the inquiry response. Markets you.
- 2. Speaker Rider** — sent with the proposal. Sets expectations on AV, travel, lodging, per diem.
- 3. Speaker Agreement** — signed before any deposit, calendar hold, or travel booking. Locks in the fee, the date, the cancellation terms, and the recording rights.

1. Fee schedule

The numbers below are based on current 2025–2026 market data for healthcare CEU instructors and credentialed clinical subject-matter experts. They are not generic “motivational keynote” rates — those are higher and would price you out of the audience that actually books you. The right comparison group is: PhD-prepared nurse educators with national instructor credentials.

Three things justify the high end of each band for you specifically: (1) AWHONN Instructor Trainer status for both Intermediate and Advanced Fetal Monitoring — a credential held by a small fraction of AWHONN instructors nationally; (2) 45+ years of bedside and academic authority; (3) a peer-reviewed publication in JOGNN. Quote at the high end of the band when all three are relevant to the booking; quote in the middle when only one or two are.

Tiered fee structure

Tier A — Community, church, advocacy, and ministry events

These are mission-aligned audiences (Go Red, NBNA chapters, church health ministries, local women’s conferences). You may choose to discount or waive fees for ministry work — that’s a personal call. Posting a stated rate, even if you negotiate down, prevents the implicit assumption that your time is free.

Format	Quoted fee	Notes
Single talk (45–60 min)	\$500 – \$1,500	Plus travel if outside Houston metro
Half-day workshop	\$1,500 – \$3,000	Plus travel and meals
Panel participation	\$350 – \$750	Plus travel

Tier B — Hospitals, nursing schools, and CEU-bearing professional education

This is your core market. Hospital staff-development budgets and university CEU programs are accustomed to these rates. Anything below this band signals that you’re an in-house lecturer rather than a credentialed external expert.

Format	Quoted fee	Notes
In-service or single CEU lecture (1–2 hr)	\$1,500 – \$3,500	Plus travel; remote-delivery option for Tier B avg. \$1,000–2,500
Half-day CEU workshop (3–4 hr)	\$2,500 – \$5,000	Plus travel, meals, lodging if overnight
Full-day CEU training (6–8 hr)	\$4,500 – \$8,500	Plus travel, meals, 1–2 nights lodging
Multi-day intensive (2–3 days)	\$7,500 – \$15,000	Plus all travel; quote per day at \$4,500–5,500/day
Curriculum review or consulting	\$200 – \$400 / hour	5-hour minimum; hourly billing with monthly invoice

Tier C — AWHONN Fetal Monitoring courses (your specialty rate)

Because you hold the Instructor Trainer credential, these courses are billed differently than general CEU work. The AWHONN student pack (\$120/student) is purchased separately by the host or the participants — it does not come out of your fee. Your fee is for instruction and CEU sponsorship.

Course	Instructor fee	Notes
Intermediate FM Course (1 day, up to 25 students)	\$3,500 – \$5,500	Plus travel; per-student materials handled by host
Advanced FM Course (1 day, up to 25 students)	\$4,000 – \$6,500	Plus travel; specialized credential premium
Instructor Trainer Workshop (preparing new instructors)	\$5,500 – \$9,000	Few people in the U.S. can deliver this
Per-student add-on above 25 students	\$50 – \$100 / student	For hosts running larger cohorts

Tier D — Conference keynotes and named lectures

Format	Quoted fee	Notes
Regional conference keynote (45–60 min)	\$3,500 – \$5,500	Plus travel and lodging
National conference keynote (60–75 min)	\$5,000 – \$7,500	Plus travel and lodging; premium for AWHONN national, NBNA national
Named lecture / endowed lecture	\$5,000 – \$10,000	University-funded lectureships often have set honoraria; ask for theirs first

Tier E — Virtual delivery

Virtual rates are typically 50–70% of in-person rates because there's no travel time and no day lost to airports. Don't go below 50% — the prep time is identical, and you're delivering identical CEU value.

Format	Quoted fee	Notes
Virtual lecture or webinar (60 min)	\$1,000 – \$2,500	Includes one Q&A round
Virtual half-day workshop (3 hr)	\$1,500 – \$3,500	
Virtual full-day training (6 hr)	\$3,000 – \$6,000	Two breaks built in; recording rights priced separately
Recording and rebroadcast license	Add 25–50% of base fee	License period typically 6–12 months

2. What the host pays for, separately from your fee

These items are reimbursed by the requesting organization on top of the speaking fee — they are not deducted from your honorarium. A clean rider attached to the proposal eliminates 90% of the awkward conversations.

Travel

- **Airfare:** Round-trip airfare. Coach domestic; premium economy or business for any flight over 5 hours. Booked by host on their account, or reimbursed within 14 days with submitted receipts.
- **Personal vehicle:** If driving: IRS standard mileage rate — 70¢/mile in 2025, 72.5¢/mile in 2026 — plus tolls and parking. Caps the host's exposure and protects you from out-of-pocket fuel cost.
- **Ground transportation:** Uber/Lyft/taxi between airport, hotel, and venue. Reimbursed with receipts. Approximately \$40–\$80 per leg in most metros; budget \$200–\$400 total.
- **Origin parking:** Airport parking at Houston origin if you drive yourself there — reimbursed.

Lodging

- **Hotel:** 3-star or higher non-smoking hotel with reliable Wi-Fi, booked and paid for by the host directly (not reimbursed). Specify a hotel within 15 minutes of the venue.
- **Number of nights:** Night-before for any morning event start; same-day return only if event ends by 3pm and a flight is reasonably available. For full-day events, two nights (arrival and event night).
- **Folio:** All taxes and incidentals (Wi-Fi, parking) covered by the host folio. You should not be required to put a personal card on file at check-in.

Meals

- **Per diem option (preferred):** Per diem of \$75/day domestic, or \$100/day for higher-cost cities (NYC, SF, Boston, DC, LA). Paid as a flat amount, no receipts required — simpler for both sides than expense reports.
- **Receipt option:** If the host prefers actuals: itemized receipts up to a daily cap of \$100 (lower-cost cities) or \$125 (high-cost). No alcohol charged to the host.
- **Provided meals:** Host-provided meals during the event (lunch, breaks, speaker dinner) reduce the per diem by \$20 per meal covered.

On-site requirements (the rider)

- **AV:** Lavalier or over-ear wireless mic for any room over 30 attendees. Handheld mic acceptable for rooms under 30.
- **Projection:** HDMI-compatible projector or large display, with a USB-C/Thunderbolt adapter. Confidence monitor at the podium for slide preview.
- **Clicker:** Wireless slide advancer (you can bring your own — bring backup).
- **Podium setup:** Small high-top or low table at podium for water, notes, clicker. Two bottles of room-temperature water.

- **Green room:** Quiet, lockable green room or office for prep 30 min before start; not a public hallway or coffee bar.
- **Handouts:** Host prints and provides handouts (PDFs sent 7 days in advance), or covers the print cost. CEU sign-in sheets and evaluation forms are the host's responsibility.

CEU-specific items

- **Accreditation:** ANCC accreditation paperwork, contact-hour calculations, and certificate distribution are the host's responsibility unless contracted separately. If the host wants you to provide CEU sponsorship through your own approved provider, add \$200–\$500 per course depending on hours.
- **AWHONN materials:** AWHONN student materials (\$120/student for FM courses) are purchased and provided by the host, separately from your instructor fee.

3. What you pay (and write off as business expenses)

As a paid speaker you are operating a business — even if you keep your hospital and faculty roles. Income from speaking is reported on IRS Schedule C (Form 1040), Profit or Loss from Business. Any organization paying you \$600 or more in a calendar year will issue a Form 1099-NEC. You owe self-employment tax (15.3%) on net profit, plus regular income tax. Every dollar of legitimate business expense reduces both.

This section is a working list of what you can deduct. None of this is legal or tax advice — review it with your CPA before filing. But if you're not tracking these, you're overpaying tax.

Travel and travel-adjacent (when not reimbursed)

- **Mileage:** Mileage to local engagements within Houston metro — 70¢/mile (2025) or 72.5¢/mile (2026). Keep a logbook or use an app (MileIQ, Everlance).
- **Airfare:** Airfare you book for yourself when host doesn't reimburse, or upgrades you elect to pay for personally.
- **Lodging:** Lodging for site visits, scouting, or stay-overs you choose to extend at your own cost.
- **Meals:** Business meals while traveling — 50% deductible. Solo meals on travel days count.
- **Conference fees:** Conference registration fees when attending to maintain credentials, network, or scout speaking opportunities.

Professional credentials and education

- **Professional memberships:** AWHONN, NBNA, Sigma Theta Tau, ANA — fully deductible.
- **License renewals:** RNC recertification, NCC certification renewal, AWHONN Instructor Trainer renewal fees — fully deductible.
- **Continuing education:** Any CEU you take to maintain credentials, plus the cost of journals (JOGNN, AJN, MCN), reference texts, and clinical guidelines subscriptions.
- **Coaching:** Speaker coaching, voice lessons, presentation-design training, public-speaking workshops.

Marketing and business development

- **Website:** OlindaJohnsonSpeaks.com domain registration, hosting, design and development costs.
- **Software subscriptions:** Email marketing services (Mailchimp, ConvertKit), CRM (HubSpot free tier), scheduling (Calendly).
- **Photography:** Professional headshots, lifestyle photography, video sizzle reel production.
- **Print marketing:** One-sheet design, business cards, branded folders, banner stand for in-person events.
- **Bureau fees:** Speaker bureau commissions if you ever use one (typically 20–30% of the speaking fee).
- **Listings & directories:** LinkedIn Premium, professional association directory listings.

Equipment and supplies (business-use percentage)

- **Computer / iPad:** Allocate by percentage of business use. A laptop used 70% for speaking work is 70% deductible — either depreciated over time or expensed in full under Section 179.
- **Phone & internet:** Business portion of cell phone bill and home internet — typically 30–60% depending on use.
- **Presentation equipment:** Wireless presentation clicker, portable backup projector, lapel mic, ring light for virtual sessions.
- **Software:** Slide design tools (Keynote, PowerPoint), Canva Pro, Adobe subscriptions, Zoom Pro for virtual delivery.
- **Office supplies:** Folders, printer ink, professional stationery, shipping costs for materials.

Insurance and professional services

- **Liability insurance:** Professional liability / errors-and-omissions coverage, separate from your hospital coverage. NSO (Nurses Service Organization) is a common provider.
- **Health insurance:** Business portion of self-employed health insurance premiums — deductible above the line, not on Schedule C, but still a write-off.
- **Accounting and legal:** CPA, bookkeeper, contract attorney — fully deductible.
- **Bank fees:** Business banking fees, credit card processing fees (Stripe, Square) on speaker payments.

Home office (if you have a dedicated space)

- If you have a room or area used exclusively and regularly for the speaking business, you can deduct either the simplified method (\$5/sq ft up to 300 sq ft, max \$1,500/yr) or the actual method (a percentage of rent/mortgage interest, utilities, insurance, repairs).
- The actual method is typically more lucrative for owned homes; the simplified method is faster and audit-safer. Your CPA can model both.

Things you cannot deduct

- **Commuting:** Personal commuting (home to your hospital job).
- **Wardrobe:** Clothing unless it's a uniform or branded apparel that can't be worn outside business contexts. A nice suit you wear to keynote does not qualify.
- **Spouse travel:** Spousal travel unless your spouse is a bona fide employee of the speaking business with a defined business purpose for the trip.
- **Entertainment:** Entertainment (theater, sporting events, concerts), even when entertaining a client — the 2017 tax law eliminated this deduction.

4. Booking workflow

A consistent process protects your calendar, your rates, and your weekends. Use this sequence for every inquiry, regardless of how the host frames the ask.

Step 1: Initial inquiry response (within 48 hours)

- Acknowledge receipt warmly. Confirm your initial interest pending details.
- Send the one-sheet PDF as an attachment.
- Ask for: event date(s), city, expected audience size, audience type (RNs, advanced practice, students, mixed), session length, format (in-person/virtual/hybrid), CEU contact-hour expectation, and budget range.
- Do NOT quote a fee in this email. The fee depends on the answers to the questions above.

Step 2: Proposal (within 5 business days of getting answers)

- Send a written proposal: scope of session, learning objectives, format, fee, what's included in the fee, what the host covers separately, and a draft rider.
- Quote one specific number, not a range. Ranges invite negotiation downward; firm numbers anchor.
- Set a response deadline (typically 14 days). Without a deadline, the calendar fills with tentative holds.

Step 3: Speaker Agreement

- Once the host accepts, send the Speaker Agreement for signature. Use a free e-sign tool (PandaDoc, DocuSign, HelloSign).
- Required clauses: full fee, payment schedule, deposit terms, cancellation terms (see below), travel arrangements, recording rights, marketing usage rights, force majeure.
- Standard payment terms: 50% non-refundable deposit on signature; balance due day of event or net-30 after delivery.
- Standard cancellation terms: 100% of fee retained if cancelled within 30 days; 50% retained if 31–60 days; deposit retained if more than 60 days. Travel costs already incurred always reimbursed.

Step 4: Pre-event

- Send slide deck, handouts, and bio for emcee introduction 7–10 days before the event.
- Confirm AV check time on arrival day — always do this, never trust setups sight-unseen.
- Submit any pre-approved travel reimbursement receipts as you incur them, not in a batch after.

Step 5: Invoicing and payment

- Invoice on event day if not pre-paid, with the agreed payment terms.
- Itemize: speaking fee (one line), travel reimbursements (separate lines per category, with receipts attached), per diem (one line, no receipts needed if flat per diem agreed).

- Always issue under your business name and EIN, not your SSN, for \$600+ payments. (You should set up an EIN through irs.gov — it's free and protects your SSN from circulating.)
- Track all 1099-NECs received against your records each January — hosts sometimes report to the wrong tax ID or omit you entirely.

5. When and how to discount

It is normal and ethical to vary your rate by audience type. What's not okay is varying it by who asks loudest or who pushes back hardest — that pattern punishes the most respectful bookers and rewards the rudest.

Acceptable reasons to discount

- Mission-aligned nonprofits with documented small budgets (church health ministries, NBNA chapters, free clinics).
- Multi-date bookings with the same host (offer 10–20% off the second and subsequent dates).
- Off-season scheduling (filling a slow week or month).
- Repeat clients (a relationship discount of 10–15% for the third+ booking).
- Recording rights waived in exchange for a higher live fee.

Reasons NOT to discount

- “Exposure” — the audience is already there to see you. Their attendance is not your payment.
- “It’s for a good cause” — every cause is good. You can give your time as a documented in-kind donation, which is itself deductible.
- “Our budget is small” from a hospital or for-profit organization — their budget is a planning choice, not a constraint on your worth.
- “We’ll pay your travel” as the entire compensation — travel coverage is the floor, not the ceiling.

Appendix: Quick reference

Annual setup checklist

- Get an EIN (free, irs.gov, 5 minutes online)
- Open a business checking account separate from personal
- Register a business name (sole proprietor DBA or LLC) with Texas Secretary of State
- Set up bookkeeping software (QuickBooks Self-Employed, Wave, FreshBooks)
- Engage a CPA who handles self-employed/small business clients
- Carry professional liability insurance (NSO or similar)
- Set up a Stripe or Square account for any direct-deposit payments

Quarterly checklist

- Pay estimated quarterly taxes (April 15, June 15, September 15, January 15) — the IRS penalizes underpayment even if you settle the full amount in April

- Reconcile speaker income against your booking calendar
- Review and tag all expenses by Schedule C category

Year-end checklist

- Collect all 1099-NECs by January 31; chase missing ones
- Total mileage logbook for the year
- Submit organized expense file to CPA by mid-February for an early filing
- Update one-sheet with the year's most notable engagements before sending out for the new year

This framework is for internal planning. Numbers reflect 2025–2026 market data and IRS rates and should be reviewed annually. Always confirm tax positions with a qualified CPA.